

Then I had to select the packages to install from a radio button menu. I didn't install KDE since I am anti K/Qt. I chose *xfce* and not DM. I highly recommend *xfce*, which is at version 4.8 right now on Slackware. It works without a hiccup. The best part about Slackware's installer is that it is *ncurses* based, which makes me feel like I am running a real UNIX-like system and not a cheap clone!

Day 2

Installed a newer version of Gambas since I had an urge to hack something not so familiar. In my opinion, it is the best way in the world to install software. It worked out quite nicely. The dependencies are listed on the Gambas homepage. I first yanked them up from slackbuilds.org, then I installed an older version of Python since I needed to test some of my apps for Debian Squeeze, which still has Python 2.6 by default (and I can't expect all my users to build and install a newer version of Python on their systems).

Day 3

Encountered my first dependency/philosophy problem. Turns out the version of Virtualbox that I acquired was 'virtualbox-qt' and since I am anti Qt/K, I had to re-download the right binaries for the GTK2 version of the Virtualbox UI.

Day 4

I had to enable the network manager and the Bluetooth services daemons from */etc/rc.d*. Created an IPtables set-up from Alien Bob's script generator <http://www.slackware.com/~alien/efg/>. It's as easy as pie and the script generated is adequate if you are running a desktop on which you don't SSH much. It's not quite effective for a high traffic server.

Day 5

Finally, set up Slackware on the ThinkPads and then it was time to rip a little hair from my head. I now had to set it up on my MacBook Pro. One thing I'd like to mention is the difference between EFI and UEFI. UEFI systems have a PROM, where the firmware is installed and can't be replaced/overwritten easily. It may brick your system if the EFI support on your UEFI system is buggy; however, Apple EFI, which is an Apple specific version of (U)EFI doesn't follow standards set by the industry. The firmware on Macintosh systems is primarily stored on the HD itself, which makes it almost immune to bricking. The way to reset the PROM is as easy as holding down 'cmd + opt + P + R', powering on the machine and waiting for three subsequent start-up chimes, which will reset the firmware on your Mac to its factory state (this also works if you forget the EFI password for your pre-2011 Mac. I know this from experience; however I am not sure about the post 2011 Macs since I don't have any). Anyway, I had to replace the stock LILO from LILO-EFI64 to be able to

boot my Mac, and had to use *rEFIt* to change the partition set-up from 'dos MBR' to 'GPT'.

Day 6

Packaged my first piece of software in Slackware's native 'tl.gz' format, which is nothing but a clever way of using GNUmake's build powers as an installation capability; subsequently, I read the Slack Book which has a new version in beta these days. Well, this version is much more evolved and it has much newer, more useful, relevant and contemporary documentation about Slackware than the current stable version of Slack Book. Stable book version: <http://www.slackbook.org/>; Newer beta book version: <http://www.slackbook.org/beta/>

Day 7

Had to set up my HP deskjet printer. To my surprise, Slackware doesn't just come with the 'Hplip' drivers; it comes with the whole HP printer suite with an official HP CUPS manager.

Day 8

Had to set up the Broadcom wireless card on my MacBook Pro (bcm 4322). Yanked *BCMfwcutter* and ran it. It pulled the firmware for my card using *wget* and it installed the firmware for the B43 driver in the Linux kernel. I just had to reboot and my Wi-Fi was working.

In the eight days that I used Slackware as my main OS on all three machines, I must say I was amazed by its simplicity and straightforwardness. Nothing comes close to it. I now have two distros that I can rely upon—Debian and Slackware. If I were to choose one (every Debian purist vein in my body is screaming as I say this) I would choose Slackware for its simplicity :) 

References

- [1] www.slackware.com; www.slackbook.org; www.linuxquestions.org (the official Slackware forums community)

Links

- [1] www.slackware.com; <http://www.linuxquestions.org/questions/slackware-installation-40/>

Special thanks:

I would like to thank Patrick Volkerding and the whole Slackware crew for answering every query I threw at them via email, and for patiently helping me resolve the countless issues I faced while breaking the packaging process because of my own foolishness.

By: Aditya Pareek

The Jaipur-based author is a UNIX hobbyist and programmer. He can be reached at irc:freemove.net or at the [#crunchbang-offtopic](https://www.youtube.com/channel/UCrunchbang-offtopic) channel. He blogs at www.unixraol.blogspot.in